Katie Boulter Wins Rain-Delayed Match at the Japan Open

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British tennis player Katie Boulter earned a strong **first-round** win at the Japan Open in Osaka, but she had to wait an extra day to finish it.

Boulter was playing Himeno Sakatsume, a Japanese player who was the home crowd's favorite. On Monday, Boulter had already won the first **set** and was leading 3-1 in the second **set** when bad weather stopped play. Rain made it impossible to continue that night.

The two players returned to the court on Tuesday. Boulter finished the job and won the match 6-3, 6-1.

"Yesterday was a tough spot to end at," Boulter said afterward. She explained that she had wanted to keep playing on Monday night, but the rain did not allow it. "It meant that I had to have the same **mindset** again today and just try to get over the line and focus on getting through the match," she said. "I think I did that."

She also said she was glad the match did not go to a third **set**.

The numbers show how well Boulter handled pressure. A **break point** is a chance for the player receiving the serve to win a game. Boulter won five of her nine **break points**. Sakatsume, who entered the tournament as a **wild card**, which means she was given a special invitation to play, had 13 **break points** but won only one.

Boulter, who is 30, will face Viktorija Golubic of Switzerland in the second round.

In other tennis news, world number nine Iga Swiatek pulled out of the Ningbo Open because of a thigh injury. That makes it harder for her to reach the WTA Finals, which feature the top eight players of the year and will take place in Indian Wells from November 8 to 15.

Word Treasure

set -- A part of a tennis match; a player usually needs to win six games to win a set.

mindset -- A person's way of thinking and attitude about what they are doing.

break point -- A chance for the player who is not serving to win that game.

wild card -- A special invitation that lets a player enter a tournament without the usual ranking.

first-round -- Describes the opening round of a tournament, when the most players are still competing.

Background you need

In professional tennis, a match is split into sets, and each set is made of games that players win by scoring points.

Outdoor tennis matches often stop for rain because a wet court is slippery and unsafe, so players finish later from the same score.

Players travel to tournaments around the world during the season, and their results earn ranking points.

The best players of the year qualify for a special season-ending event, so injuries late in the year can affect who gets in.

Break it down

LEAD: Katie Boulter won her rain-delayed first-round match at the Japan Open
KEY EVENT: Play stopped Monday with Boulter a set and 3-1 up; she finished Tuesday
+- WHO: Katie Boulter vs. home favorite Himeno Sakatsume
+- WHERE: Osaka, Japan
+- RESULT: 6-3, 6-1
EVIDENCE: Boulter won five of nine break points; Sakatsume won one of 13
NEXT: Boulter faces Viktorija Golubic; Iga Swiatek withdraws from Ningbo with a thigh injury
OPEN QUESTION: Can Boulter keep her strong form in the second round?

Why it matters

Boulter's win shows how athletes must stay focused through interruptions, and late-season results and injuries help decide who reaches the year's biggest final event.

Test what you remember

1. Why did Boulter's match take two days?

(A) She was injured
(B) Rain stopped play on Monday
(C) The lights went out
(D) Her opponent was late

2. What was the final score of Boulter's win?

(A) 4-6, 6-3, 6-2
(B) 6-0, 6-0
(C) 7-5, 6-4
(D) 6-3, 6-1

3. Who was Boulter's opponent?

(A) Viktorija Golubic
(B) Himeno Sakatsume
(C) Iga Swiatek
(D) Elena Rybakina

4. How many break points did Sakatsume win out of 13?

(A) Five
(B) All 13
(C) Nine
(D) Only one

5. Why did Iga Swiatek pull out of the Ningbo Open?

(A) A family wedding
(B) Bad weather
(C) A thigh injury
(D) A travel delay

6. Where will the WTA Finals take place?

(A) Osaka
(B) London
(C) Ningbo
(D) Indian Wells

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Katie Boulter: Said stopping overnight was tough, but she kept the same mindset and was pleased to avoid a third set.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):